BJP votes in the 43 seats across these states. Following Kejriwal's arrest, both parties expect to ride on a sympathy wave, at least in Delhi, where the BJP had swept all the seven seats in two consecutive Lok Sabha polls. However, even with the sympathy vote, the AAP-Congress alliance will have a wide chasm to cross—the BJP's vote share. In 2019, the BJP polled 63 per cent votes in Gujarat and 57 per cent in Delhi. To bring down the BJP's fortunes with their collective might, the two parties will need a massive swing in their favour.

In Haryana, too, the coalition, with a collective vote share of just 32 per cent in 2019, faces the daunting task of weaning away a substantial chunk from the BJP's 58 per cent vote share. The solo forays by the Dushyant Chautala-led Jannayak Janta Party (JJP), a Jat-based party, and the BSP, which represents Dalits, will deny the alliance the opportunity to amass votes from those communities. The Congress must also keep a lid on the feuds within if it wishes to take advantage of the anti-incumbency against ruling BJP.

Punjab presents a more complicated picture, as the state is poised to witness, for the first time, a quadrangular contest in the Lok Sabha election, with the four key players—the ruling AAP, Congress, BJP and SAD (Shiromani Akali Dal)—fighting solo. The going will be tough for all four parties for Punjab's 13 seats, of which the Congress won eight, SAD and BJP two each and AAP one in 2019. "By default, the Congress is likely to retain its 2019 performance as there is huge anti-incumbency against AAP, and the BJP and SAD are side players," predicts Professor Ashutosh Kumar of Panjab University.

THE SOUTHERN BULWARK

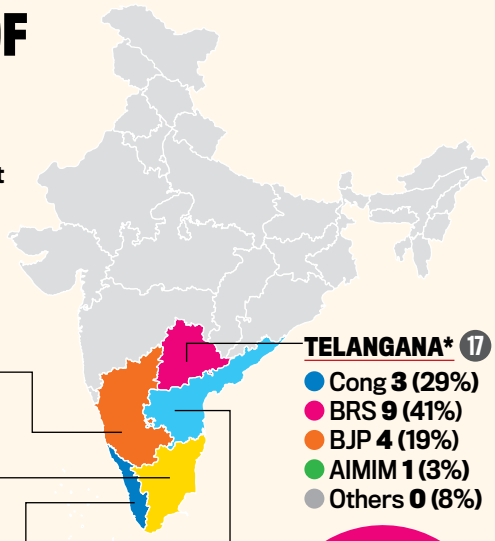
Barring Karnataka, the South has always been the Achilles heel of the BJP. Team I.N.D.I.A. is confident of scoring high both in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, where the BJP's absence has been more stark. In Tamil Nadu, the DMK-led I.N.D.I.A. bloc looks set to grab a majority of the 39 seats despite the campaign blitzkrieg Prime Minister Modi and his party have unleashed. To beat anti-incumbency, the DMK has dropped six sitting MPs and negotiated with its ally, the Congress, to change some of the seats from which it contested the last time. Chief Minister M.K. Stalin has also launched several welfare schemes to woo women and the youth, who were traditional supporters of the AIADMK.

That the Congress doesn't want any decline in its tally of 15 out of Kerala's

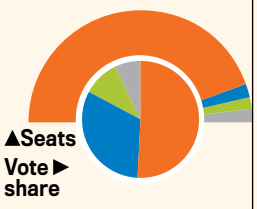
WHAT I.N.D.I.A. LACKS IS A STRONG LEADER WITH A MASS CONNECT AND ABILITY TO COUNTER MODI'S POPULARITY. NOT ONLY IS RAHUL OFTEN MISSING IN ACTION, HIS GAFFES UNDO HIS PERSONAL AURA OF SINCERITY

FORTRESS OF THE SOUTH

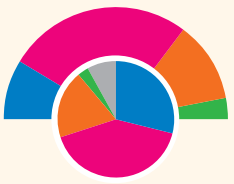
Regional parties and the Congress have kept the BJP at bay in the South. Karnataka was an exception, but now Congress is trying to clip BJP wings here too



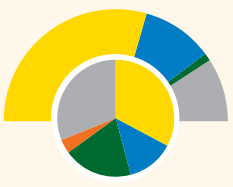
KARNATAKA 28
- BJP **25** (51%)
- Cong **1** (32%)
- JD(S) **1** (10%)
- Others **1** (7%)



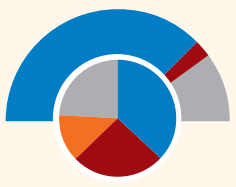
TELANGANA* 17
- Cong **3** (29%)
- BRS **9** (41%)
- BJP **4** (19%)
- AIMIM **1** (3%)
- Others **0** (8%)



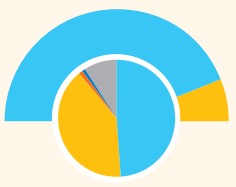
TAMIL NADU 39
- DMK **23** (33%)
- Cong **8** (13%)
- AIADMK **1** (18%)
- BJP **0** (4%)
- Others **7** (32%)



KERALA 20
- Cong **15** (37%)
- CPI(M) **1** (26%)
- BJP **0** (13%)
- Others **4** (24%)



ANDHRA PRADESH* 25
- YSRCP **22** (49%)
- TDP **3** (40%)
- BJP **0** (1%)
- Cong **0** (1%)
- Others **0** (9%)



**The TDP is now a BJP ally along with the Jana Sena that had cornered 6% vote share in 2019*

SEATS WON IN LS 2019 (Vote share %) ● Total